

Finding Black-Led Creation and Use of Economic Instruments to Support Freedom Seekers in 1840

By: 1838 Black Metropolis
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Main Article Content

This research was supported by the Along Freedom's Journey History grant from the New Jersey Historical Commission. The article presents evidence that Black-led Underground Railroad leadership in Philadelphia employed sophisticated economic instruments like stocks and mortgages to support freedom seekers, with documented communication channels between Philadelphia and Free Haven, New Jersey—a known Underground Railroad sanctuary town.

Philadelphia Vigilant Committee and Economic Leadership

The Philadelphia Vigilant Committee (VC), founded in 1837, provided comprehensive assistance to freedom seekers including "short-term housing, travel, medical assistance, and clothing." The VC operated as an information hub coordinating these services.

In 1839, the Agricultural and Mechanics Association of Pennsylvania and New Jersey (AMAPNJ) was established. Many VC leaders, including Jacob C. White Sr., Daniel Colly, and Ralph Smith, also held leadership positions in the AMAPNJ, suggesting interconnected missions.

AMAPNJ Structure and Purpose

Members purchased shares for \$10 (approximately \$330 in today's dollars), receiving repayment of 25 cents weekly over roughly 40 weeks. The constitution authorized the treasurer to apply collected funds toward "purchases of land and improving the same, stock purchasing, materials, foals, and fixtures, paying of agents, teachers, instructors."

This structure indicates the organization pooled resources from the free Black community for purposes including land acquisition, property improvement, and educational establishment.

Land Investment and Housing Support in Free Haven

Jacob C. White Sr., identified as a likely AMAPNJ treasurer, held the organization's financial records. Historical documents show his involvement in Free Haven land transactions. An 1846 letter from lawyer William Watson concerns a deed for White's land purchase.

In March 1840, a mortgage was provided for Margaret Williams for a house in Free Haven, with Jacob C. White Sr. as the assumed lender and Ralph Smith as the builder. Building materials were subsequently purchased from suppliers including Parry Randolph and J.C. Wilkins between August and October 1840, specifically for construction in "Noble Village."

- The documented timeline includes:
- March 7, 1840: Margaret Williams mortgage
 - August-October 1840: Building materials purchases
 - March 12, 1841: Additional construction work by Richard Gauff
 - May 15, 1841: Materials for lime, gravel, and chimney work

Agricultural Support and Community Development

An 1842 letter from free Black man Samuel Sharp in Free Haven to Jacob C. White Sr. requesting tobacco seeds suggests White provided agricultural assistance, potentially representing the "improving the land" aspect of AMAPNJ's mission.

Regional Network Documentation

Free Haven, now Lawnside, New Jersey—established as the first Black municipality in New Jersey—was home to Peter Mott, an Underground Railroad conductor. A March 30, 1843 National Anti-Slavery Standard excerpt indicates "the settlement of many rent payers and their conversion to home owners," supporting evidence of organized settlement efforts.

Lawnside remains home to descendants of both freedom seekers who arrived through Peter Mott's station and Philadelphia-based Black community leaders, including descendants of the Forten family.

Conclusion

The research demonstrates that Black leaders employed financial instruments—stocks and mortgages—toward supporting freedom seekers and settling them in sanctuary towns. The documented connections between Philadelphia's VC/AMAPNJ leadership and Free Haven's thriving Black community suggest an established Underground Railroad network by 1840.

Images

- AI Imagining of Margaret Williams standing in front of her home in Free Haven, New Jersey — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_0d1299588959403c8f3ca5af6c9448b3~mv2.png
- VC Notes showing clothing assistance for Freedom Seekers and economic leader Daniel Colly — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_16c1b8d510d6421e9604826e4a8c4ead~mv2.jpg
- Cover of the AMAPNJ Constitution — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_6c82004af59f40cbae9ac9196bb1fdb8~mv2.png
- Jacob C White and Daniel Colly in the Vigilance Committee Notes — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_8c4b1635a5b0449d9776491ff073433d~mv2.jpg
- Excerpt from the Constitution of the AMAPNJ — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_f7bafac6b35f4db8a162d35ff1319640~mv2.jpg
- Jacob C. White, Sr. — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/f61430_4fcd42a9ff38462c8b84a9a15d9812e1~mv2.jpg
- Stock Share Certificates from the AMAPNJ — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_a299b39fbe2d4e9bbc9091d4e5eace54~mv2.png
- Excerpt from the AMAPNJ Constitution — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_e9ca5c00aea44adb8d08c9e6d9a4f6d5~mv2.jpg
- William Watson Letter in the Jacob C White Collection — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_dee81e6500fa49169d0ed0af376a7b06~mv2.jpg
- Map showing Free Black Sanctuary Towns — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_19d8815a67cf47afb8485110a032f137~mv2.png
- M. Williams from Volume 4, Page 38 of the 1838 PAS Census — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_60a017d61ad04e07919007f35797ea9d~mv2.png
- Margaret Williams Mortgage excerpt — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_676e095bc278404d85669d1fdb5dbdf5~mv2.jpg
- Receipt from Parry Randolph — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_28b7d4b2c3154eaa97226eb4cdd90a9c~mv2.jpg
- Letter from the Jacob C. White collection — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_c6f61ae78fc846b29677c07567aa796e~mv2.jpg
- Anti-Slavery Standard March 30, 1843 — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_ed99be4b983543bf8cf6fea3aa37b0d6~mv2.jpg

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